

again. I could retire decades before becoming eligible for Social Security. I could travel, read, learn, and relax rather than continue to grind away at the job.

It took me two years from that day at Heathrow to figure out a way to retire. At age 35 I did it—with class. The formula in this book tells how you can do it too.

All my life I had wanted nothing more than a piece of the corporate action. At age 5 I played at my desk for hours at a time. When I was 7 I begged for a file cabinet for Christmas. My parents and teachers told me I could be anything I wanted to be, and I believed every word of it. When I was in high school my hero was Jonas Cord of *The Carpetbaggers*. As I recall, Jonas failed in his private life, but I viewed that as a minor miscalculation. As they say, money may not buy happiness but it sure takes the sting out of being unhappy.

I didn't just dream about money and power and expense-account living—I planned for it. Before starting my career I got an M.B.A. from Stanford Graduate School of Business. After Stanford I went for the gold and loved every minute of it. Seven years later, at age 30, I was one of the youngest partners in the history of Peat, Marwick, Mitchell & Co., the international accounting firm. By 1984 I had a huge office, a leather chair, and a view of a polluted river. Someone brought me coffee, someone else made my phone calls, and a highly trained staff did the work. I was so high up in the world that instead of talking on the phone in intervals, I talked on the phone all day long. I played golf at the best clubs and flew to places like London, Rome, Miami, and Rio de Janeiro.

In late 1984, a few months shy of my 36th birthday, I hung up my pencil. I retired before I had my first pair of bifocals, before the gold watch could tick away my best decades. I didn't win a lottery, have a rich uncle, or rob a bank. I didn't make a fortune in real estate, catch a run in the stock market, or invent a new toy. I wasn't a millionaire. All I had were some savings, equity in my home, and a few minor invest-